

doc-autonomy-of-local-assembly

Open / Uncertain · Ecclesiology › Nature of the Church · doctrine · divided_lineages · Brethren distinctive · confidence: low

Statement under examination

Each local assembly is autonomous under Christ's headship, governed by its own elders, not subordinate to a denominational hierarchy or external bishop.

Rationale

The New Testament lexical record places elders (presbyteroi G4245) and overseers (episkopoi G1985) in each local assembly (ekklesia G1577) as the named shepherding office (Acts 14:23, Acts 20:17-28, Titus 1:5, 1 Pet 5:1-3). The same record contains no example of a supra-local bishop with jurisdictional authority over multiple ekklesiai, nor any example of a denominational hierarchy exercising governance over local elders. The terms episkopos and presbyteros are used interchangeably for the same office (Titus 1:5-7, Acts 20:17-28). However, the canonical pattern also shows real translocal apostolic activity: Paul appoints elders in churches he planted (Acts 14:23), instructs Titus to do the same (Titus 1:5), corrects local assemblies by letter (1-2 Corinthians, Galatians), and the Jerusalem council issues a decision binding on Gentile churches (Acts 15). The Bible names elders in every town with no regional bishop above them, and it also shows apostolic and council-level oversight that is not the same as bare congregational autonomy. The proposition that each local assembly is autonomous under Christ's headship, governed by its own elders, with no external denominational hierarchy is lexically consistent with NT eldership texts but is not lexically demonstrated as a binding canonical pattern excluding all other polities. Verdict honestly contested between congregationalist, presbyterian, and episcopal readings of the same texts.

Reasoning

The question is whether the New Testament teaches that each local church runs itself under Christ alone, governed by its own elders, with no outside bishop or denominational headquarters over it. The strongest reason for the autonomous reading is the lexical pattern in the elder texts. Paul and Barnabas appointed elders in every church (Acts 14:23). Paul told Titus to appoint elders in every town (Titus 1:5). In Acts 20:17 Paul calls the elders of the church of Ephesus to himself, and in verse 28 the same men are called overseers who shepherd the flock of God. The two words elder and overseer are used for the same office. Peter tells elders to shepherd the flock of God that is among you (1 Peter 5:1-2). The New Testament names elders in every town, never a single bishop over a region with elders under him. In Matthew 18:17 Jesus tells a believer who cannot resolve a sin issue to tell it to the church, and the local gathered church carries out the discipline. In 1 Corinthians 5 Paul tells the Corinthian church as a body to put the unrepentant man out. The strongest counterargument is that the New Testament also shows real authority above the local elders. Paul plants churches and corrects them by letter. The apostles in Acts 15 hold a council in Jerusalem and issue a binding decision for the Gentile churches. Paul tells Titus, a translocal worker, to set things in order in the churches of Crete and to appoint their elders. 3 John shows John the apostle exercising authority over a local elder named Diotrephes who refused to receive the apostolic delegation. So the Bible names elders in every town and also shows apostolic and council oversight that goes beyond the local elders. The honest reading is that the New Testament gives a clear local-eldership pattern but does not lexically rule out a translocal structure. Christians who hold that the apostolic oversight pattern continued through bishops, or that elders should connect across churches in presbyteries and synods, can read the same texts in good faith. The verdict cannot be settled from the words alone in a way that excludes the other historic polities.

Denominational landscape

Christians have read the same New Testament texts and reached three different historic polities. The autonomous and congregational position, held by most Baptist bodies including the Southern Baptist Convention as a voluntary cooperative of autonomous churches, by Open Brethren and most Exclusive Brethren assemblies, by most non-denominational churches, and by congregational Anabaptist Mennonite traditions, holds that the local assembly under its own elders is the highest visible church court and that all wider cooperation is voluntary. The presbyterian position, held by the Presbyterian Church in America, the Orthodox Presbyterian Church, the Reformed Church in America, the Christian Reformed Church, and most continental Reformed bodies, holds that local elders connect upward into presbyteries and general assemblies that exercise real authority over local sessions. The episcopal position, held by the Roman Catholic Church, by the Eastern Orthodox communions, by the Oriental Orthodox communions, by the Anglican Communion, by the United Methodist Church and most Methodist bodies, by some Lutheran national churches, and in connectional form by Pentecostal-Holiness bodies such as the Assemblies of God in district structure, the Church of God in Christ, and the International Pentecostal Holiness Church, holds that bishops in apostolic succession govern dioceses and that local presbyters serve under episcopal oversight. The Roman Catholic Church adds the further claim of universal jurisdiction held by the Pope as the successor of Peter. The patristic record shows the monepiscopal pattern already named in Ignatius of Antioch around the year 110, urging believers to do nothing without the bishop. The majority of historic Christianity, measured by lineage age and global membership, has been episcopal. Congregational and autonomous polities are the minority globally but significant in the Anglo-American evangelical world. This dispute is in-house and sub-gospel. A Baptist who holds local-assembly autonomy and a Catholic or Anglican or Orthodox Christian who holds episcopal polity disagree on church government, not on the gospel of Jesus Christ. Public-record cult or heterodox movements do exist that build authoritarian structures around a single founder (the Iglesia ni Cristo around Felix Manalo, the Branhamites around William Branham, Mormonism around Joseph Smith and the Latter-day prophet structure), but their problem is not episcopal polity as such; their problem is extra-canonical authority claims that override Scripture. Bare episcopal polity is not cult-grade.

Position thresholds

Would die for if challenged	No
Cult marker if denied	No
Would visit if otherwise	Yes
Would participate if otherwise	Yes
Would serve if otherwise	Yes
Would be member if otherwise	Yes
Would let children be taught otherwise	Yes
Would marry if held otherwise	Yes
Would publicly correct if otherwise	No

Notes

Polity is in-house Christian disagreement, not a gospel boundary or a cult-marker. The cult-marker bar requires canonical demonstration and gospel-implicating denial; neither obtains here. The majority of historic Christianity has been episcopal (Catholic, Eastern Orthodox, Oriental Orthodox, Anglican, Methodist, some Lutheran national churches) or presbyterian (continental Reformed, Presbyterian, some Reformed Baptist). Congregational and autonomous polities are the minority globally but significant in

Anglo-American evangelicalism. Carriers of the congregational and autonomous reading: most Baptist bodies including the Southern Baptist Convention as a voluntary cooperative of autonomous churches, Open Brethren and most Exclusive Brethren assemblies, most non-denominational churches, congregational Anabaptist Mennonite traditions, many independent evangelical churches. Carriers of presbyterian polity: Presbyterian Church in America, Orthodox Presbyterian Church, Reformed Church in America, Christian Reformed Church, Reformed Presbyterian Church of North America, most Reformed continental bodies. Carriers of episcopal polity: Roman Catholic Church, Eastern Orthodox communions, Oriental Orthodox communions, Anglican Communion, United Methodist Church and most Methodist bodies, some Lutheran national churches, Pentecostal-Holiness bodies with connectional polity such as the Assemblies of God (district-connectional), the Church of God in Christ, the International Pentecostal Holiness Church. The stem of this question is heavily pre-loaded with Reformed-Baptist-Brethren confessional vocabulary on polity (autonomous, under Christ's headship, denominational hierarchy, external bishop). It frames episcopal and presbyterian polities as the contrast class while implicitly endorsing the congregational reading. Flag stem-pre-loaded-verdict. The neutralized form asks what polity the New Testament names and whether the named pattern excludes other polities. A Christian who holds presbyterian or episcopal polity in good faith from the same NT texts is not denying the gospel; the question of polity is sub-gospel. The user is Plymouth Brethren-adjacent; the Brethren tradition holds autonomous-assembly polity as a distinctive but this is the formation on trial, not the rubric. The honest verdict from a tradition-neutral lexical baseline is that the autonomy-of-the-local-assembly proposition as stated is lexically permissible but not lexically mandated by the canon, and the verdict is contested across major lineages.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: **yes**

Neutralized form. What polity (autonomous-congregational, presbyterian, or episcopal) does the New Testament name for the relationship between local assemblies and any translocal authority, and is any one of these polities lexically mandated to the exclusion of the others?

Notes. The stem asserts the congregational verdict (each local assembly is autonomous, governed by its own elders, not subordinate to denominational hierarchy or external bishop). This is the Reformed-Baptist-Brethren confessional position presented as if neutral. The neutralized form preserves the lexical question without taking the congregational reading as given. Flag stem-pre-loaded-verdict.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. congregational-autonomous, presbyterian-connectional, episcopal-hierarchical

analogia scripturae invoked

Competing lens verdicts

congregational-autonomous · **affirms**:

presbyterian-connectional · **complicates**:

episcopal-hierarchical · **denies**:

All three polities operate within orthodox Christianity. The grammatico-historical reading alone does not settle the question because the New Testament names plural local eldership clearly and also names translocal apostolic activity clearly without explicit lexical guidance on what happens after the apostles. The autonomy verdict requires a hermeneutical judgment that apostolic-era translocal authority did not transfer to any continuing office. That judgment is held by Baptist, Brethren, and congregational traditions; it is denied by presbyterian and episcopal traditions. The Brethren-on-trial discipline applies: the autonomous-assembly reading is the user's inherited position but lacks unambiguous pan-canonical lexical mandate. Honest baseline: contested, with all three major lenses operative within historic Christianity.

Scripture (apparatus + interlinear)

Acts.14.23 · **for** · genre: narrative

Key term. χειροτονήσαντες cheirotonesantes G5500 (having appointed, aorist participle active); πρεσβυτέρους presbyterous G4245 (elders, plural); κατ ἐκκλησίαν kat ekklesian G2596 G1577 (in each church)

Force. Paul and Barnabas appoint elders, plural, in each local church. The participle cheirotoneo originally meant to stretch out the hand to vote; here it is used by the apostles for their own appointing action. The grammar is plural elders per single ekklesia, with each ekklesia named distributively (kata + accusative). Lexically this is the foundational text for plural-eldership at the local level. It does NOT comment on whether translocal apostolic oversight continues; it shows the apostles establishing the local office.

Titus.1.5 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key term. καταστήσης katastēsēs G2525 (you might appoint, aorist subjunctive); πρεσβυτέρους presbyterous G4245 (elders, plural); κατὰ πόλιν kata polin G2596 G4172 (in every town)

Force. Paul instructs Titus, a translocal worker, to appoint plural elders in every town in Crete. The pattern again is plural elders distributed across towns. The complicating layer the verse itself creates: Titus is a translocal apostolic delegate exercising authority across multiple local churches to set their eldership in order. The text supports plural local eldership and also documents a translocal commissioning agent over multiple assemblies. Congregational and episcopal readings both find footholds in the same verse.

Acts.20.17 · **for** · genre: narrative

Key term. τοὺς πρεσβυτέρους τῆς ἐκκλησίας tous presbyterous tes ekklesias G4245 G1577 (the elders of the church)

Force. Paul summons the elders, plural, of the church of Ephesus, singular. One city, one ekklesia, plural elders. The lexical pattern aligns with Acts 14:23 and Titus 1:5: plural eldership for the local assembly.

Acts.20.28 · for · genre: narrative

Key term. ἐπισκόπους episkopous G1985 (overseers); ποιμαίνειν τὴν ἐκκλησίαν τοῦ θεοῦ poimainein ten ekklesian tou theou G4165 G1577 G2316 (to shepherd the church of God)

Force. The same men called elders (presbyteroi) in verse 17 are called overseers (episkopoi) here, with the verb poimaino (to shepherd) describing their function. Lexically the two titles refer to one office in the New Testament. The later patristic distinction between bishop and presbyter as separate offices is not yet present in the Ephesian eldership of Acts 20. This is a strong text against a tiered bishop-over-presbyters structure read as apostolic.

1Pet.5.1-3 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. πρεσβυτέρους presbyterous G4245 (elders); ποιμάνετε poimante G4165 (shepherd, aorist imperative); ποίμνιον τοῦ θεοῦ poimnion tou theou G4168 G2316 (flock of God); ἐπισκοποῦντες episkopountes G1983 (exercising oversight); μὴ κατακυριεύοντες me katakyrieuontes G2634 (not lording it over)

Force. Peter calls himself a fellow elder and addresses elders, plural. The verbs poimaino and episkopeo describe the same shepherding function. Verse 3 explicitly forbids katakyrieuein, lording it over those entrusted to them. The text places real shepherding authority in plural elders at the local level and explicitly forbids domineering rule. This is a strong text for non-domineering plural local eldership and against authoritarian top-down rule.

Matt.18.15-20 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. εἶπε τῇ ἐκκλησίᾳ eipe te ekklesia G2036 G1577 (tell it to the church); ἔθνικος ethnikos G1482 (Gentile, pagan); δῆσῃτε ἐπὶ τῆς γῆς desete epi tes ges G1210 G1093 (whatever you bind on earth); ὅπου γὰρ εἰσιν δύο ἢ τρεῖς συνηγμένοι εἰς τὸ ἔμὸν ὄνομα hopou gar eisin duo e treis synegmenoi eis to emon onoma G4863 G1519 G1700 G3686 (where two or three are gathered in my name)

Force. Jesus places the final visible court of discipline at the gathered local church (te ekklesia, dative singular, the assembled body). The binding-and-loosing authority is given to the gathered community. There is no appeal above the local church named in this text. This is a strong text for the local-assembly-as-final-discipline-court reading. The complicating layer: the text says nothing about whether translocal apostolic oversight continues, which is a separate question.

1Cor.5.4-5 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key term. συναθρόντων ὑμῶν synachthenton hymon G4863 (when you are gathered together); παραδοῦναι τὸν τοιοῦτον τῷ Σατανᾷ paradounai ton toiouton to Satana G3860 G4567 (deliver such a one to Satan)

Force. Paul addresses the Corinthian church as a body and instructs them, as a gathered assembly, to put the unrepentant incestuous man out of fellowship. The disciplinary act is congregational. The complicating layer: Paul as a translocal apostle is the one issuing the directive and asserting that he has already judged the matter (verse 3), so even here the congregational action is in obedience to apostolic instruction from outside the local body. The text supports both congregational discipline and apostolic translocal authority operating together.

3John.1.9-10 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key term. Διοτρέφης ὁ φιλοπρωτεύων αὐτῶν Diotrophes ho philoproteuon auton G1361 G5383 (Diotrophes who loves to be first among them); οὐκ ἐπιδέχεται ἡμᾶς ouk epidechetai hemas G3756 G1926 (does not receive us)

Force. John the apostle writes to oppose a local figure, Diotrophes, who loves to have the preeminence and refuses to receive John's delegation and the brethren. The text shows an authoritarian local figure rejecting apostolic oversight, with the apostle naming it as wrong. The autonomy reading uses this as a warning against authoritarian centralized power. The episcopal reading uses it as evidence of legitimate translocal apostolic authority over local figures. Both readings find footholds.

Acts.15.6-29 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key term. ἀπόστολοι καὶ πρεσβύτεροι apostoloi kai presbyteroi G652 G4245 (apostles and elders); ἔδοξεν τῷ ἁγίῳ πνεύματι καὶ ἡμῖν edoxen to hagio pneumati kai hemin G1380 G4151 G40 (it seemed good to the Holy Spirit and to us)

Force. The Jerusalem council includes apostles and elders deliberating together and issuing a binding decision that is then carried as a written ruling to the Gentile churches of Antioch, Syria, and Cilicia (verse 23). This is a translocal council exercising real authority over multiple local churches. The text complicates bare autonomous-congregational polity at the lexical level. The autonomy reading typically treats this as a one-off apostolic-era event not normative for non-apostolic eras. The presbyterian and episcopal readings treat it as the seed pattern of conciliar and synodical authority.

1Tim.4.14 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key term. μετὰ ἐπιθέσεως τῶν χειρῶν τοῦ πρεσβυτερίου meta epitheseos ton cheiron tou presbyteriou G1936 G5495 G4244 (with the laying on of the hands of the presbytery)

Force. Timothy received his gift through the laying on of the hands of the presbyteriou, the council of elders. The noun presbyterion (G4244) names a collective body of elders. The complicating layer for strict autonomy: the verb suggests an act involving multiple elders, plausibly including elders from beyond a single local church, since Timothy travels with Paul. The text neither mandates nor excludes translocal eldership connection; it shows ordination by a council of elders.

Rev.2.1 · complicates · genre: apocalyptic · figures: apocalyptic-symbolism

Key term. τῷ ἀγγέλῳ τῆς ἐν Ἐφέσῳ ἐκκλησίας to angelo tes en Epheso ekklesias G32 G1722 G1577 (to the angel of the church in Ephesus)

Force. The seven letters in Revelation 2-3 are addressed each to the angelos (messenger or angel) of the local church. Some episcopal readings (most prominently the Anglican tradition) treat the seven angeloi as seven local bishops, one over each city. The autonomous reading treats them as literal angels or as personifications of each congregation. The text is lexically ambiguous and apocalyptic-symbolic in genre; it cannot bear the weight of settling polity by itself, but it is regularly cited in the dispute.

Eph.4.11 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key term. ἀποστόλους apostolous G652 (apostles); προφήτας prophetas G4396 (prophets); εὐαγγελιστάς euangelistas G2099 (evangelists); ποιμένας καὶ διδασκάλους poimenas kai didaskalous G4166 G1320 (shepherds and teachers)

Force. Paul names five ministry gifts given by the ascended Christ to the church. Some are inherently translocal (apostles, evangelists). The complicating layer: this text places at least some named ministries above or alongside the local poimenas (shepherds), which the episcopal and presbyterian readings take as evidence that the church Christ built includes translocal offices. The autonomous reading treats the apostolic and evangelistic gifts as functional and itinerant but not jurisdictional.

1Tim.3.1-7 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key term. ἐπισκοπή episkope G1984 (overship, office of overseer); ἐπίσκοπος episkopos G1985 (overseer)

Force. Paul gives qualifications for the episkopos. The noun is singular here (verse 2: dei oun ton episkopon, the overseer must be), which some episcopal readings cite as evidence of a single overseer per local church. The autonomous reading reads the singular as generic (any overseer) rather than as a single office over plural elders, especially given the plural elders in Acts 20:17/28 referring to the same Ephesian church Timothy was serving in 1 Tim 1:3. The grammar permits both readings.

Heb.13.17 · **neutral** · genre: epistle

Key term. πείθεσθε τοῖς ἡγουμένοις ὑμῶν peithesthe tois hegoumenois hymon G3982 G2233 (obey your leaders); ὑπέικετε hypaikete G5226 (submit)

Force. Believers are commanded to obey and submit to their leaders. The participle hegoumenoi (those leading) is generic and does not specify polity. The text supports real authority of named leaders in the local body, regardless of which polity (congregational, presbyterian, episcopal) holds the office. Lexically neutral on the autonomy question.

2Cor.13.10 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key term. ἐξουσίαν ἣν ὁ κύριος ἔδωκέν μοι exousian hen ho kyrios edoken moi G1849 G2962 G1325 (authority which the Lord gave me); εἰς οἰκοδομὴν καὶ οὐκ εἰς καθαίρεσιν eis oikodomen kai ouk eis kathairesin G1519 G3619 G2506 (for building up and not for tearing down)

Force. Paul names the authority the Lord gave him to wield over the Corinthian church from outside it. This is direct apostolic jurisdictional authority over a local church the apostle did not currently reside in. The text complicates strict autonomy: at least during the apostolic era, real translocal authority existed by Christ's commissioning. The autonomy reading typically holds that this authority does not transfer to non-apostolic offices; the episcopal reading holds that it does, through apostolic succession.

Concordance lemmas traversed

G1577, G4245, G1985, G1983, G1984, G4165, G4168, G4166, G4244, G5500, G2525, G2596, G4172, G2316, G2634, G3860, G4567, G4863, G2036, G1482, G1210, G1700, G3686, G1361, G5383, G1926, G3756, G652, G1380, G4151, G40, G1936, G5495, G32, G1722, G4396, G2099, G1320, G3982, G2233, G5226, G1849, G2962, G1325, G3619, G2506, G1519

complicating texts searched: Yes

Counter-witness traditions

patristic · Ignatius of Antioch, Epistle to the Smyrnaeans, chapter 8 (c. 110), ccel.org
Schaff ANF Vol 1 · **denies** · **verified**

"Let no one do anything connected with the Church without the bishop. Let that be deemed a proper eucharist which is administered either by the bishop or by one to whom he has entrusted it."

patristic · Cyprian of Carthage, On the Unity of the Church (c. 251), ccel.org Schaff ANF
Vol 5 · **denies** · **unverified**

"He can no longer have God for his Father who has not the Church for his mother. The episcopate is one, of which a part is held by each in its entirety."

catholic_magisterial · Catechism of the Catholic Church paragraphs 880-887 on the apostolic college and episcopal collegiality, vatican.va · **denies** · **unverified**

"The Lord made Simon alone the rock of his Church. The college of bishops, with the pope at its head, governs the universal Church. Bishops succeed the apostles by divine institution."

lutheran · Augsburg Confession Article XIV Of Ecclesiastical Order and Article XXVIII Of Ecclesiastical Power, bookofconcord.org · complicates · verified

“No one should publicly teach in the Church or administer the Sacraments unless he be regularly called. The power of the Keys, or of the bishops, is a power or commandment of God to preach the Gospel.”

anglican · Thirty-Nine Articles of Religion (1571), Article XXIII Of Ministering in the Congregation and Article XXXVI Of Consecration of Bishops, churchofengland.org · denies · unverified

“It is not lawful for any man to take upon him the office of public preaching, or ministering the Sacraments in the Congregation, before he be lawfully called and sent to execute the same.”

reformed · Westminster Confession of Faith Chapter 31 Of Synods and Councils · complicates · unverified

“For the better government and further edification of the Church, there ought to be such assemblies as are commonly called synods or councils. It belongs to synods to determine controversies of faith.”

reformed · Second London Baptist Confession (1689) chapter 26 paragraphs 7-8 and 14-15 · affirms · unverified

“To each of these churches thus gathered, according to His mind declared in His word, He has given all that power and authority which is in any way needful for their carrying on that order in worship and discipline which He has instituted.”

methodist · United Methodist Articles of Religion, Methodist polity structure with itinerant bishops and conferences, umc.org/en/content/articles-of-religion · denies · unverified

“The Methodist church is governed by an episcopal structure with bishops who appoint pastors to local churches under the authority of annual conferences and the General Conference.”

anabaptist · Schleithem Confession (1527), Article V Of Pastors in the Church of God · affirms · unverified

“The pastor in the Church of God shall be one who is wholly according to the rule of Paul. Of him is required and given to be supported by the Church which has chosen him.”

pentecostal · Assemblies of God Statement of Fundamental Truths, district-connectional polity, ag.org/Beliefs/Statement-of-Fundamental-Truths · complicates · unverified

“The Assemblies of God operates as a cooperative fellowship of autonomous local churches connected through district councils and a General Council, blending congregational and connectional features.”

eastern_orthodox · Orthodox Church in America, teaching on bishops and apostolic succession, oca.org · denies · unverified

“The Orthodox Church is governed by bishops who stand in unbroken apostolic succession. Each diocese is the local church gathered around its bishop in eucharistic communion with all other Orthodox bishops.”

Web sources

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/acts/14-23.htm>

“cheirotonesantes G5500 aor part act; presbyterous G4245 plural; kat ekklesian G2596 G1577 distributively, plural elders per single local church.”

complicates · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/titus/1-5.htm>

“katasteses G2525 aor subj 2sg, you might appoint; presbyterous G4245 plural; kata polin G2596 G4172, in every town. Titus as translocal commissioning agent.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/acts/20-28.htm>

“episkopous G1985 overseers; poimainein G4165 to shepherd; ekklesian tou theou G1577 G2316. Same men called presbyteroi in verse 17 are episkopoi here. One office, two titles.”

supports · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/1_peter/5-2.htm

“poimante G4165 aor impv 2pl; poimnion G4168 flock; episkopountes G1983 pres part. Plural elders shepherd, not lording over (me katakyrieuontes G2634).”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/matthew/18-17.htm>

“eipe G2036 aor impv; te ekklesia G1577 dat sg, the local gathered assembly. Final visible discipline court placed at the local-church level.”

complicates · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/3_john/1-9.htm

“Diotrephes ho philoproteuon G5383 pres part, loving to be first. John exercises translocal apostolic authority over a local figure who refuses to receive the brethren.”

complicates · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/strongsgreek/1577.htm>

“ekklesia G1577 114 NT occurrences. Refers to local assemblies (Acts 8:1, 1 Cor 1:2, Col 4:15) and to the universal church (Matt 16:18, Eph 1:22). Both uses are canonical.”

opposes · category: patristic_archive · <https://ccel.org/ccel/schaff/anf01>

“Ignatius of Antioch c. 110 names the threefold bishop-presbyters-deacons pattern as established. Monepiscopal polity is documented within decades of the apostles.”

nuance · category: tradition_primary · <https://bookofconcord.org/augsburg-confession/of-ecclesiastical-order/>

“Augsburg XIV: no one should publicly teach or administer Sacraments unless regularly called. Lutheran polity preserves bishops in function without requiring apostolic succession.”

Flags

- stem-pre-loaded-verdict
- confession-tradition-divergence
- needs-elder-input